



Monitoring, Evaluation, Learning and Impact Assessment (MELIA) Plan

Gender Equality and Inclusion Accelerator

June 2025

Table of Contents

1. Gender Equality and Inclusion Accelerator overview and results framework.....	3
Accelerator overview	3
Theory of change.....	3
Results framework	9
2. Monitoring plan for HLOs and outcomes	9
Data collection strategy	10
3. Evaluation plan.....	12
Evaluation studies.....	12
Evaluation collaboration plans.....	12
4. Impact assessment	13
Program/Accelerator impact overview.....	13
IA activities and collaboration plans.....	13
IA studies	15
5. Learning and adaptive management.....	16
Learning.....	16
Annual review and adaptive planning.....	16
6. MELIA resources	17
MELIA budget and staff.....	17
7. Data management.....	17
General approach	17
Annex 2. MELIA studies template	18
Annex 3. MELIA budget templates	25
Annex 4. MELIA study types	28

1. Gender Equality and Inclusion Accelerator overview and results framework

Accelerator overview

Multidimensional inequalities in FLWS are deep-rooted, widespread, and projected to grow over the next decades. Current inequalities are being exacerbated by a convergence of interrelated crises — a polycrisis — encompassing climate change, environmental degradation, geopolitical instability and changing consumption patterns.

The recent [UN Women Snapshot](#) estimates that the global cost of failing to invest in basic skills for women and in gender equality is US\$10 trillion a year. For FLWS, this translates to a gender gap in farm productivity and wage gap which if closed would reduce the number of food-insecure people by 45 million. If it is not, climate change will continue to grow this gap: for every 1° C increase in long-term average temperatures, women farmers lose 24% more of their income than men. Further, in agriculture-dependent low- and middle-income countries, heat waves and floods cost women-run households US\$53 billion more per year than they cost male-headed households. Women are losing 8% more of their income (US\$37 billion), when temperatures surge and 3% more (US\$16 billion) when floods hit ([source](#)).

The recent [GEYSI focused ISDC interim report](#) points to the vulnerability of rural youth, particularly rural women, emphasizing the poor working conditions in the rural sector for youth. The report highlights that within agrifood systems, the key challenges that affect youth engagement are limited or lack of access to productive resources, services and markets, negative perception, and limited attractiveness of the agrifood sector, and limited meaningful engagement in policy processes

Addressing gender disparities and social inequalities is not only a human right but also a means to tackling the other megatrends that hinder the achievement of resilient FLWS, as also recognized by the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). The need for transformation to achieve just and sustainable FLWS is urgent and critical. Social inequalities and gender disparities in FLWS — across intersecting dimensions of gender, age, socioeconomic status, and ethnicity, among others — represent a “wicked problem” that is systemic, complex, and deeply entrenched. As such, solutions must be comprehensive, multi-actor, multi-sectoral, and evolutionary rather than narrow or isolated.

Components

Area of Work **Accelerating Solutions for Impact** takes a socioecological systems approach by bundling innovations to respond to the differentiated needs and challenges faced by women, youth, IP&LC, and other socially excluded groups.

Area of Work **Accelerating Change through Evidence** fosters structural change across the FLWS ecosystem. This is achieved by assisting FLWS actors to use evidence from research to set policies, to set priorities, and to define solutions for delivery and scaling and by sharing capacities to conduct quality GESI and youth research while tracking impacts.

Theory of change

Accelerator level theory of change

CGIAR's ability to deliver on an inclusive and just food system is limited by significant challenges that require change in agricultural research processes. FLWS innovations are often developed with little or no attention to social inequalities, treating women and men as homogeneous groups. Ignoring complex social issues may exacerbate inequalities and prevent some FLWS innovations from achieving their full potential of benefits for end users.

To catalyse change and empower women and youth as partners and drivers of equitable FLWS solutions, FLWS actors (including CGIAR, national governments, and other AR4D partners) must: (a) adopt a [socioecological system framework](#) to identify solutions to guide interventions towards key leverage points in the multiple systems (social, economic, technological, and governance) that feed into inclusive and just FLWS and result in transformation and empowerment; and (b) ensure FLWS actors are equipped with the tools, methods, and evidence required to enhance access to, and adoption of, innovations, measures, and technologies that promote the resilience and livelihoods of women, particularly from IP&LC, as well as youth and other socially excluded groups.

To achieve our vision of a world where gender equality, opportunities for youth, and social inclusion drive transformation towards equitable, sustainable and resilient agrifood systems, the Accelerator will work along three impact pathways:

- I. Co-designing place-based gender and inclusion research with actors at country and grassroots level, yielding context-specific evidence and innovations;
- II. conducting place-based research in partnership with CGIAR Science Programs to inform and enhance the equity, uptake, and effectiveness of SP innovations;
- III. delivering evidence and innovations to influence global discourse, policy, and programs.

Following these pathways, four end-of-program outcomes are to be achieved by 2030:

1. Agrifood systems actors use evidence and innovations generated in the Accelerator to address structural barriers to gender equality and social inclusion;
2. AR4D actors, including CGIAR and NARES, disseminate, replicate and scale gender-responsive, transformative and socially inclusive innovations;
3. Decision-makers and agrifood system actors use metrics and analytics to understand and monitor progress in addressing structural barriers to gender equality and social inclusion; and ultimately
4. Women, youth and socially excluded groups have equitably benefited from innovations designed to enhance sustainability and outcomes from agrifood systems.

These outcomes are interconnected and interdependent, and the achievement of each is not linear. The achievement of the first three outcomes is also a precondition to the achievement of the fourth 2030 outcome. The 2030 outcomes will be achieved through the two interconnected Areas of Work (AoWs): Accelerating Solutions for Impact and Accelerating Change through Evidence. These two AoWs build on the significant demand and momentum created through the CGIAR Gender Equality Initiative (HER+) and GENDER Impact Platform. Their strong partnerships, lessons learned, and evidence gathered offer a solid foundation upon which the Accelerator's outputs and outcomes in this portfolio can be built.

Accelerating Solutions for Impact takes a socioecological systems approach by bundling innovations to respond to the differentiated needs and challenges faced by women, youth, IP&LC, and other socially excluded groups. For example, women may derive more benefit from a

new irrigation technology if it is bundled with training, financing, and marketing of the produce, and if the users are organized as a mutual-support group ([Pasha et al., 2023](#)).

Accelerating Change through Evidence fosters structural change across the FLWS ecosystem. This is achieved by assisting FLWS actors to use evidence from research to set policies, to set priorities, and to define solutions for delivery and scaling and by sharing capacities to conduct quality GESI and youth research while tracking impacts.

A core principle of this Accelerator is the co-design of solutions and their implementation in a participatory manner. Building on experiences from the past portfolio, AoW Change expands work on targeting, demand signalling, evidence synthesis, and facilitation of uptake. The joint identification of innovations will lead to solutions and form a basis for developing metrics to assess impact and for building capacity to take up solutions and create positive feedback loops for learning and adjustment.

Partnerships are key to accelerating change and reaching the Accelerator's 2030 and intermediary outcomes. Within CGIAR, working with the nine Programs and the other two Accelerators will require an iterative relationship, with the Programs contributing to the thematic AoW of the Gender Equality and Inclusion Accelerator and the Accelerator contributing methodologies, evidence, tools, approaches, and best practices that raise the GEYSI ambitions of the Programs and drive a coherent CGIAR-wide GEYSI research agenda.

Beyond CGIAR, the Accelerator harnesses high-level support, fosters strategic partnerships, and influences global discourse to build an enabling external environment for GESI in FLWS research through effective communication and engagement. It builds and sustains global coalitions and networks to accelerate the impact of GESI initiatives on a broader scale.

This Accelerator works closely with bilateral projects and programs of the German Agency for International Cooperation (GIZ), and the International Fund for Agricultural Development (IFAD), among others, to advance positive GEYSI outcomes in FLWS. Relevant research and outcomes are also driven by strong engagement with research networks such as FARA and its subregional organizations, the Asia-Pacific Association of Agricultural Research Institutions (APAARI), the Southeast Asian Regional Center for Graduate Study and Research in Agriculture (SEARCA), and national agricultural research systems (NARES) such as the Brazilian Agricultural Research Corporation, the Chinese Academy of Agricultural Sciences, the Ethiopian Institute of Agricultural Research, the Indian Council of Agricultural Research (ICAR), the Kenya Agricultural and Livestock Research Organization (KALRO), and the Uganda National Agricultural Research Organization.

Moreover, the Accelerator engages with national governments and multilateral organizations to understand their information needs in support of evidence-based policymaking and program design and their preferences for accessing this evidence. The Accelerator's work with global partners — such as the African Development Bank (AfDB), Asian Development Bank (ADB), Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations (FAO), IFAD, Sustainably Growing Africa's Food Systems (formerly, Alliance for a Green Revolution in Africa [AGRA]), and The World Bank — builds on previous successful engagement, such as collaborations on the Status of Women in Agrifood Systems and the Voluntary Guidelines on Gender Equality and Women's and Girls' Empowerment in the Context of Food Security and Nutrition. With its presence across Centers and connections to a broad spectrum of actors, the Accelerator will continue to help make agricultural innovation more inclusive.

The main assumptions that underpin the achievement of the 2030 outcomes are: i) that co-designed gender transformative approaches will bring about gains in productivity, food, nutrition, and economic security, which will motivate broader stakeholders to scale them through their own programs; ii) that decision-makers and other FLWS stakeholders will have vested interest in measuring progress of their interventions and investments in the empowerment of women and youth using robust metrics and analytics; iii) that timelines and political economy will create opportunities for stakeholders to act on increased understanding, including through policy reforms, program re-design or strategy revisions; iv) that there will be continuity of stakeholders over this period and sufficient funding to take action on the evidence; and v) that women, youth and socially excluded groups see benefits and are interested in participating and influencing decision-making processes.

Area of Work Accelerating Solutions for Impact theory of change

The first impact pathway (see above) will mostly be pursued through this AoW by working with partners on the ground and will address the overarching research question “Which integrated solutions, implemented under which conditions and contexts, can accelerate a transition toward just and resilient FLWS that deliver gender and social equality and inclusion and other desirable FLWS outcomes?”

The AoW on Solutions builds on the [conceptual framework](#) that surfaces four dimensions of inequality and identifies four types of change, from the individual to the systemic level, that need to be pursued in concert to transform agrifood systems. At the individual level, the changes needed to achieve gender equality in FLWS require redressing unequal power relations by **increasing women’s empowerment** and **promoting equitable access to and control** over FLWS resources throughout the entire life cycle of a person, from youth to old age. But these changes alone cannot transform food systems because disadvantage stems from deep-seated biased social structures. As such, FLWS will be transformed only by **fostering equitable and inclusive norms** and **policies** that provide a conducive environment for empowerment and equity, while **amplifying the voice and influence** of women, youth, and socially excluded groups.

Together with CGIAR Science Programs and partners, *Accelerating Solutions* co-develops and inclusively scales integrated solutions that challenge the multiple dimensions of inequality, overcoming inclusion challenges specific to, for instance: Climate change adaptation and mitigation; Agricultural technology design and use; Breeding and genetic innovations; FLW value chains and market systems; Natural resources management (e.g., water, biodiversity, landscapes); Livestock, fisheries, and aquaculture.

CGIAR’s gender research has shown that integrated solutions that promote new agricultural technologies — while addressing norms that hinder gender-equal access and adoption of these technologies — can help reduce the gender productivity gap. Moreover, research shows that, while in general women are more vulnerable than men to the shocks of climate change, greater access to resources, technologies, knowledge, and financial services can improve women’s climate resilience. Ensuring equitable social norms and an equal voice in climate discussions, negotiations, and solutions are also crucial. Removing the structural barriers facing women and other groups in farming, forestry, fishery, aquaculture, livestock, and their value chains contributes to greater equality, improved resource management, better livelihood opportunities, and improved diets — thus strengthening resilience capacities.

The *Accelerating Solutions* also co-designs **youth**-responsive solutions to lift barriers and create the opportunities that many youth want in FLWS. Engaging youth requires researchers to think beyond farming, fields, and food production. For instance, digital technology related to agricultural information, markets, credit, or value addition may draw youth into agriculture. But how can we ensure that these innovations are inclusive and sustainable?

The *Accelerating Solutions* also expands beyond a gender focus to address other intersecting axes of marginalization and exclusion. This intersectional approach considers how people's social characteristics interact to shape the constraints and opportunities they face in FLWS. A social inclusion approach ensures that otherwise excluded groups, such as people with disabilities, IP&LC, people of lower caste, and vulnerable tribal communities, take part in designing the solutions that shape their lives and livelihoods. For instance, the Accelerator builds on CGIAR's experience in supporting land tenure for IP&LC, co-designing socio-technical innovation bundles with Scheduled Castes and tribes in India, and ensuring social inclusion in climate finance, among other work.

This AoW in collaboration with the AoW on *Accelerating Change*, creates tailor-made tools and standardized metrics that enable conceptually sound, accurate, and consistent measurement of gender equality in institutions, power relations, and agency. This will be the basis for co-designing and refining tools to measure progress toward gender equality, empowerment, and inclusion objectives and commitments and targets in institutions, policies, programs, and projects amid the new reality of polycrisis.

This AoW will deliver 2 high-level outputs related to measuring gender and intersectionality norms as well as measuring voice and leadership in agrifood systems groups and institutions. It will also deliver 13 high-level outputs related to co-designing, piloting, and assessing the effectiveness and affordability of solutions that address challenges related to the four dimensions of inequality mentioned above.

We envisage that if all high-level outputs (HLOs) are successfully delivered and the assumptions hold, then five intermediate outcomes will be achieved, reflecting the change in the knowledge, skills, attitude, practice, and policy among stakeholders who participated in the co-design and delivery of the interventions/solutions:

- 1.1.** Agrifood systems stakeholders will use the tools, methods, and solutions co-developed with the Accelerator to better pinpoint and act on restrictive norms at different institutional levels across diverse agrifood systems and contexts;
- 1.2.** Agrifood systems stakeholders will use in their own practices the evidence generated in the Accelerator on the importance of supporting women and youth and engage in co-developing strategies to empower;
- 1.3.** Agrifood systems stakeholders will use the evidence generated in the Accelerator to inform their own strategies to promote women's access to resources and opportunities for resilient livelihoods across the agrifood systems;
- 1.4.** Agrifood systems stakeholders will use the tools, approaches, and learnings gained through collaboration with the Accelerator to amplify the voices of women, youth, and socially excluded groups within agrifood systems policymaking;

1.5. Agrifood systems stakeholders will use the evidence and approaches developed in CGIAR to design, pilot, and scale up youth-responsive solutions to increase youth involvement in and benefits derived from agrifood systems.

The achievement of the intermediate outcomes in AoW 1 is underpinned by a few assumptions. All HLOs are based on the assumptions that the longstanding relationships with partners and co-developed research will promote the buy-in; that the research is relevant for the stakeholders' own programmes and this will facilitate the uptake of the innovations; that the timelines and political economy will create opportunities for stakeholders to act on increased understanding of the issues; that there will be sufficient funding for stakeholders to take action on the evidence; and that the political will and commitment among stakeholders will be sustained to actively partner and invest in co-design processes and solutions. All of the overarching assumptions for AoW 1 are addressed through the work of the AoW 2.

There are several other assumptions that are specific to individual HLOs. For example, the investment in the interventions that address norms is based on the assumptions that the gender and intersectional norms are amenable to change in the shorter term and that changes can occur fast enough to keep the stakeholders motivated while implementing gender transformative approaches, as well as that GTAs bring about gains in productivity, food, nutrition and economic security to increase their use by the stakeholders. Furthermore, the investment in promoting voice and agency is based on the assumptions that women, youth and socially excluded groups are indeed interested in and have capacity to participate and influence decision-making processes.

Area of Work Accelerating Change through Evidence theory of change

The AoW on Change will mainly support and pursue changes along the Accelerator's second and third impact pathways (see above), to change research practices and influence global processes in agrifood systems. This work is based on the premise that CGIAR's ability to deliver an inclusive and just food system is limited by significant challenges that require change in agricultural research processes. Agrifood system innovations are often developed with little or no attention to social inequalities, treating women and men as homogeneous groups. Ignoring complex social issues may exacerbate inequalities and prevent some agrifood systems innovations from achieving their full potential of benefits for end users.

Accelerating Change focuses on creating conducive conditions for rigorous, solution-oriented gender, youth and social inclusion research by engaging with researchers and leaders in CGIAR and FLWS actors and by amplifying the influence and use of this research among relevant end-users to contribute to wide-scale impact on gender equality, social inclusion, and meaningful opportunities for youth in FLWS. This AoW addresses two main overarching research questions: "What resources and capacities are needed for CGIAR Science Programs to enhance the equity, uptake and effectiveness of their innovations?" and "How can institutional change be fostered to move from commitment to action towards integrating gender and inclusion into global discourse, policy and programs and catalize equality in FLWS?"

As such, the AoW on Change delivers 11 high-level outputs related to developing research methodologies, metrics, and analytics; identifying and filling evidence gaps and synthesizing existing evidence; as well as capacity development of both social and bio-physical researchers to conduct impactful research to promote equitable agrifood outcomes. This AoW also invests in creating spaces and opportunities for researchers to exchange knowledge and learn from each

other, and in driving institutional change within and outside of CGIAR to create enabling conditions for inclusive research.

We envisage that if all HLOs are successfully delivered and if the assumptions hold, then 3 intermediate outcomes will be achieved, reflecting the change in the discourse, capacity, attitudes, and practices among researchers and decision-makers within CGIAR and in a broader agrifood systems research ecosystem:

2.1. CGIAR, NARES, multilateral organizations, NGOs, CSOs, the private sector, and governments will use the methodologies and metrics developed by the Accelerator to conduct rigorous and ethical research, monitor practices and measure empowerment and inclusion in their programs and practices;

2.2. CGIAR, NARES, multilateral organizations, NGOs, CSOs, the private sector, and governments will use the evidence generated by CGIAR and its partners to inform their decisions, set their priorities and targets, and make investments; and

2.3. CGIAR and non-CGIAR researchers, policymakers, NARES, NGOs, CSOs, and private sector actors will form networks and drive institutional change toward a truly inclusive environment that prioritizes the right GESI research in and outside CGIAR.

The same general assumptions that underpin the HLOs in the AoW on Solutions are relevant to the AoW on Change. All HLOs are based on the assumptions that the longstanding relationships with partners and co-developed research will promote their buy-in; that the research is relevant for the stakeholders' own programs which will facilitate the uptake of the evidence; that the timelines and political economy will create opportunities for stakeholders to act on increased understanding of the issues; that there will be sufficient funding to generate the evidence and for stakeholders to take action on the evidence; and that the political will and commitment among stakeholders will be sustained to actively partner and invest in co-design processes and solutions.

All HLOs in the AoW on Change are also based on the assumptions that the longstanding relationships with partners fosters their sustained political will and commitment to working toward inclusive and just agrifood systems and to use evidence; that the evidence is relevant, packaged and disseminated in a format that is fit-for-purpose for the partners and other stakeholders, and that that there will be sufficient funding to generate the evidence and for stakeholders to take action on the evidence.

ToC diagram: Diagram in this [link](#)

Results framework

Please refer to the Results Framework attachment

2. Monitoring plan for HLOs and outcomes

This section outlines how the Accelerator will monitor delivery of HLOs and progress towards outcomes.

Data collection strategy

The Accelerator is committed to results-based management principles to plan, monitor, and evaluate the Accelerator's investments toward its intended results. This means that the emphasis in MEL will be on tracking **changes** in knowledge, skills, capacities, as well as institutional and individual attitudes, practices and policies (for institutions). Various deliverables will be tracked for accountability purposes, but they will not be counted as results – they will be however periodically assessed to determine whether they lead to intended results (changes).

Data collection strategy is outlined in the Results Framework (see attachment). In summary, data for HLOs will be collected annually. Monitoring process will be closely linked to the planning process – the Accelerator has developed templates that link each planned deliverable to an HLO and its indicator. Monitoring data will be collected against these indicators and will focus on, for example, substantial knowledge products that present information required by the indicator. That said, various products will be produced for communication, dissemination, promotion, etc. of co-designed solutions or method/metrics/tools, but only select ones will be counted against the indicator to avoid duplication and inaccurate representation of the achievement of results. HLO indicators data will be reported back by researchers to the Accelerator programme management unit (PMU) and will be verified through project reports, training reports and knowledge products repositored on CGSpace.

Data and reporting on HLOs from W3 and bilateral projects mapped to the Accelerator will be checked by Center delegates for the Accelerator for quality assurance. Data will be cross-checked and validated at the Accelerator level during reporting period.

The Accelerator will use the following quality assurance check list for reporting evidence against HLO indicators:

- The result commissioned by the Accelerator – initial conceptualization and thinking started at the Accelerator level.
- The Accelerator contributed more than half of the funding for the result.
- For knowledge products, a credible science product (a paper) will be reported and counted, rather than a slide deck.
- Other criteria will be developed after the inception phase.

Data for outcomes will be collected biennially recognising that changes at outcome level happen more slowly. This data will be collected through interviews and surveys with different groups of stakeholders along the three impact pathways, namely partners at the country level (on the ground) who collaborate in the AoW on Solutions, representatives of the CGIAR Science Programmes, and select global and regional partners who collaborate in the AoW on Change. Indicator reference sheets will be developed by the PMU to define the scope and meaning of each indicator for each stakeholder group, as well as define most appropriate data collection method for each.

Joint annual programmatic reviews will be held with the Accelerator leadership team and ideally with select implementation actors as part of the monitoring and learning process. The

Accelerator will embrace continuous critical reflection; review using the TOC; and use lessons learned for priority re-setting, annual planning, and as input to reports.

3. Evaluation plan

Evaluation studies

Evaluation studies are included in the template in Annex 2. In summary, a baseline study is planned in the last quarter of 2025. A mid-term study will be conducted in the third year to evaluate the progress toward outcomes. Adjustments for improvement will be made to the TOC and Accelerator implementation strategy. An endline study will be conducted in the last three months of the Accelerator to determine the progress made in achieving intermediate outcomes and 2030 outcomes. The endline evaluation will be used to assess the performance of the Accelerator against outcome indicators and targets.

Evaluation collaboration plans

The Accelerator will collaborate with all CGIAR Science Programmes to conduct collaborative evaluations and assess progress along the second impact pathways (see above). The Accelerator will also collaborate with the W3 and bilateral projects mapped to it, to assess their contribution to the mapped Accelerator outcomes, particularly those mapped to HLOs related to STIBs and access to resources. These collaborations will be crucial to inform strategies applied along the respective impact pathway that aims at influencing CGIAR from within.

The Accelerator will also collaborate with the partners on the ground working with the Accelerator's teams in target countries in AoW on Solutions. These partners will be crucial in providing insights into assumptions underpinning the uptake and scaling of co-designed solutions.

4. Impact assessment

Program/Accelerator impact overview

The Accelerator and its Areas of Work (AoWs) directly support the Accelerator's 2030 outcomes by generating robust evidence on strategies to close gender gaps and foster equality in food, land, and water systems. Through coordinated efforts under AoW on Solutions—and its five sub-Areas of Work, the program will generate rigorous evidence on the effectiveness of gender-transformative interventions, bundled innovations, enabling systems promoting resource control and resilience, inclusive leadership, youth integration, and targeted strategies across agrifood systems through impact assessments. This includes examining the links between women's empowerment and resilience and identifying scalable bundled solutions in South Asia and Sub-Saharan Africa. It will assess what works within financial services, agricultural extension, and social protection systems to strengthen women's resource control, livelihoods, and resilience.

This evidence will inform innovations and institutional changes that strengthen women's agency, economic empowerment, climate resilience, voice and leadership, and the inclusion of youth. Activities under AoW on Solutions contribute directly to CGIAR's portfolio-level impact areas, with a primary focus on gender equality, followed by climate adaptation, food and nutrition security, poverty reduction, and finally, environment.

The Accelerator's impact strategy is built on the assumption that shifting harmful gender norms and unequal power dynamics is foundational to achieving sustained, system-level transformation in FLWS. Detailed assumptions can be found in the (please refer to the Results Framework attachment). Strong relationships with Science Programs such as Breeding for Tomorrow, Climate Action, Food Frontiers and Security, Better Diets for Nutrition, and Scaling for Impact, ensuring gender-focused research is integrated across CGIAR's Portfolio.

IA activities and collaboration plans

The Gender Accelerator's approach to impact assessment (IA) relies on the premise that research questions should drive the methodological approach and depending on the decisions that need to be informed, the appropriate type of evidence must be generated. Based on this, the IA activities of the Accelerator use both causal and non-causal impact assessments—recognizing that only causal approaches can allow to attribute changes observed to a particular intervention innovation, while non-causal approaches assess contributions to observed changes, using quantitative, qualitative and mixed methods. Given the complexity of gender dynamics, a diverse set of methodologies is essential. This enables the program to assess not only whether innovations are effective, but also how they work, why they work, and under what condition.

The Gender Accelerator works closely with other CGIAR Science Programs. For example, the Gender Accelerator has also partnered with the Breeding for Tomorrow Science Program to conduct coordinated causal impact assessments using harmonized designs and indicators

across CGIAR's five impact areas. The Gender Accelerator has also partnered with Food Frontiers and Security and Policy Innovations on conducting causal impact assessments examining the effectiveness of CGIAR innovations designed to enhance women's voice and agency in communities on gender equality, poverty reduction, and nutrition. The Gender Accelerator has additionally partnered with Food Frontiers and Security, Better Diets for Nutrition, and Scaling for Impact on causal impact assessments to evaluate effective interventions within social protection, agricultural intervention, and financial systems to promote women's and socially excluded groups' resource control, livelihoods, and resilience. Also, the Gender Accelerator has been in discussion with the Scaling for Impact Science program to try to implement more coordinated impact assessments in which common methodologies and indicators are used to be able to aggregate results in a more systematic way. Two of the sub-areas of work under AoW1 benefit from the expertise of a Dutch Senior Expert funded by NWO, especially for studies focused on the effectiveness of GTAs and Socio-Technical Innovation Bundles (STIBs).

While each AoW has distinct research priorities, many IA studies cut across sub-areas and research questions, requiring coordinated—rather than siloed—efforts. The Gender Accelerator's Senior Scientist for Impact Assessment plays a key role in aligning studies, supporting proposal development, and identifying funding opportunities. In several cases, funding for implementation of the innovations to be assessed is secured, but additional support is still needed for IA; SPIA and other sources are being pursued to fill this gap.

Several impact assessment studies—both causal and non-causal, using quantitative and qualitative methodologies—are planned across the five sub-areas of work (SAoWs) under AoW 1 – Solutions to generate evidence on effective, promising, and cost-efficient strategies to close gender gaps and promote equality in food, land, and water systems (FLWS). Studies will assess the effectiveness of Gender Transformative Approaches (GTAs) in shifting gender norms, particularly in West and Central Africa (WCA) and East and Southern Africa (ESA), as well as the effectiveness of socio-technical innovation bundles (STIBs). Studies also build upon the work done HER+, particularly for the role of social protection in promoting women's climate resilience and in amplifying voice and influence of women. A new effort to aggregate evidence across coordinated cross-center qualitative studies to assess the downstream impacts of interventions to amplify women's voice will be an important methodological contribution to CGIAR—as evidence aggregation across qualitative studies is rare—and to the broader evidence on voice and leadership within FLW institutions as a pathway to driving impact at scale.

The initial IA plans aim to generate evidence on:

- Gender Transformative Approaches: Rigorous impact assessments will evaluate the effectiveness of gender transformative interventions to inform future research and policy, with a focus on West and Central Africa (WCA) and East and Southern Africa (ESA).
- Socio-Technical Innovation Bundles (STIBs): Evidence will be generated on the performance and cost-effectiveness of STIBs through impact assessments, supporting future development and policy decisions, particularly in WCA, ESA, and South Asia (SA).
- Empowerment and Resilience: Research will explore the relationship between women's empowerment and resilience to multiple stressors—economic, environmental, and

conflict-related—supporting the design and scaling of integrated solutions in SA and Sub-Saharan Africa (SSA).

- Financial and Extension Systems: Impact assessments will identify effective strategies within financial services and agricultural extension to enhance women's resource control and livelihoods, especially in ESA and SA.
- Social Protection Systems: assessments will identify targeted interventions within social protection systems that build resilience for women and socially excluded groups in fragile and climate-affected areas across ESA, WCA, SA, and CWANA.
- Inclusive Leadership: studies will assess the effectiveness of inclusive leadership interventions on women's voice, agency, and downstream FLWS outcomes in WCA and SA, with expansion to MENA and SEA.
- Youth integration: studies will assess the effectiveness of approaches to successfully integrate young men and young women into FLWS, aimed at informing future research and policymaking in ESA, WCA and SA.

Ongoing refinement of the impact assessment (IA) portfolio will continue as implementation progresses and specific innovations and sites for assessment are identified. The Gender Accelerator is also planning a workshop in June 2025 with gender researchers and IA focal points to further refine these plans, particularly in coordination with other Science Programs and Centres. Collaboration with SPIA is key to ensuring alignment of efforts and methodological coherence.

In terms of indicators, we expect that all impact assessments will report on women's access to productive assets, women's input in productive decisions, and women's control over the use of income, aligning with the revision of indicators conducted with the PPU last year. Given the strong set of tools already developed by the GENDER Impact Platform (e.g., the WEAI family of indices and tools to measure gender norms), we also aim to promote the use of harmonized tools and indicators. By defining indicators in a consistent manner, we can enable better aggregation of results across different impact assessments—recognizing, of course, that this will also depend on the specific methodologies used in each assessment.

IA studies

The impact assessment (IA) studies outlined here are preliminary ideas based on research interests and priorities already discussed and aligned with the Higher-Level Outcomes (HLOs). At this stage, it is still too early to provide detailed information on timelines, sample sizes, or costs. While some studies have secured funding, others are still in the planning phase. As noted previously, the Gender Accelerator is organizing a workshop that will help refine key research questions to be addressed through IA, in collaboration with other Science Programs and Centres. This process will also help identify relevant innovations to assess, laying the groundwork for robust IA proposals. Although we have a clear sense of the research questions we aim to address, the specific impact assessment designs and methodologies, indicators measurement, sample sizes, timelines, and budgets are yet to be determined. Please also note that the list of ongoing impact assessments may not be exhaustive of all the studies that are being conducted.

5. Learning and adaptive management

The Accelerator team will document, share, and make use of lessons learned for continuous improvement. Adaptive management should be based on both operational process-related learning, making use of lessons as they arise, and research-based learning, making use of lessons in a periodic reflective process that focuses on revisiting the Accelerator ToC.

Learning

The Accelerator embraces the importance of learning and continuous improvement throughout the portfolio lifecycle. Findings from tracking progress (HLOs) and assessments (outcomes) will be used to refine strategies and implementation. This may include changes to implementation plans, adjustments to targets, or even adjustments to the overall approach (TOC) if this proves to be necessary.

Learnings from joint annual reviews will involve identifying best practices – what works well in specific sub-AoWs – and exploring where those can be replicated in other sub-AoWs. Findings from the mid-term study will be used to identify and address specific problems that may be hindering the progress. These learnings will also be used to inform re-prioritization if required.

At the place-based implementation level (mainly in AoW on Solutions), learning will be integrated in the co-design on a continuous basis and any necessary adjustments will be made based on feedback and situations on the ground.

Annual review and adaptive planning

The Program/Accelerator will build on the experience of the 2022–24 Portfolio approach to adaptive management. Once updated guidance on the adaptive management is available, details key changes made to delivery plans and the rationale for those changes will be documented and tracked.

6. MELIA resources

MELIA budget and staff

The Accelerator will rely on two MEL officers (senior and junior), an IA senior scientist, a research fellow, and the community of practice formed by the MEL officers from the participating Centers and target countries, especially to mainstream best practices across the bilateral projects mapped to this Accelerator. Please refer to the MELIA budget and staff tables in Annex 3.

7. Data management

General approach

Data management in this Accelerator will fully comply with the [CGIAR Open and FAIR Data Assets Policy](#).

Data collection methods are shown in the Results Framework attachment.

Program level data on HLO indicators will be stored in a central institutional platform as reported in PRMS. Data from outcome studies and impact assessments will be stored in a designated central platform. For research implemented through the Accelerator funding, the Accelerator will develop and sign data sharing agreements with implementing centres and partners.

For the management of qualitative data, the Accelerator will use and promote [a guide](#) developed by the GENDER Impact Platform for making qualitative data FAIR – using the GENNOVATE case study, the first of its kind, to make data open access.’

Annex 2. MELIA studies template

This table is a provisional plan and a living document. It will be updated once a year.

MELIA Study title	Lead Center and contact	Result level	Result(s) evidenced by this study	Indicator(s) evidenced by this study	Assumption(s) assessed by this study	Geographies (scope)	Methods and design approaches	Other Program(s) / Accelerator(s)	Start date for the study	End date for the study	Study cost (USD)	How related to past evaluations (SG or others)
Provide a short name for the MELIA Study	Assign the Lead Center and primary contact	Choose from: Intermediate outcome, 2030 Outcome, or Impact	Indicate the result short title from the Results Framework	Indicate the indicator title from the Results Framework	Provide the assumption(s) statement from the Results Framework	Indicate the location(s) where the study will be conducted	Indicate the methods and design approaches that will be used for the study	List the Program(s) and Accelerator(s) you will collaborate with or coordinate for the implementation of this study.	Indicate the Start date	Indicate the End date	Indicate the cost of the study	Link this study to relevant past studies – if applicable
GTA and farmer based organisations; research question: what is the added value of integrating a GT intervention into a cassava-based technical intervention	IITA, IFPRI					Tanzania, Nigeria	Causal impact assessment		Q1 2026	Q3 2026		

Gender Equality and Inclusion Accelerator MELIA Plan

within farmer organizations ?												
GTA and edutainment; research question: does exposure to edutainment, which promotes a CGIAR innovation combining a youth-targeted poultry business model and GT messaging, lead to changes in attitudes, behaviours and gender norms that support young women's participation and empowerment in poultry business?	ILRI, IFPRI					Kenya	Causal impact assessment		Q4 2025	Q1 2027		
Effectiveness of STIBs; research question: what are the						TBD in WCA, ESA, SA	Causal impact assessment					

Gender Equality and Inclusion Accelerator MELIA Plan

most effective socio-technical innovation bundles in improving women's productivity, income and resilience in AFS in specific contexts?												
Components of STIBs; research question: what combination of social and technical components within a STIB is most effective in improving outcomes for women in AFS? Which specific components drive the greatest impact?						TBD in WCA, ESA, SA	Causal impact assessment					
Empowerment and resilience: research question: what is the						TBD in SA and SSA	Causal impact assessment					

Gender Equality and Inclusion Accelerator MELIA Plan

relationship between women's empowerment and their resilience to economic, environmental and food systems shocks in SA and SSA? Which dimensions of women's empowerment most strongly contribute to household resilience and how this evidence inform the design and scaling of integrated innovation bundles?												
Financial and extension systems; research question: which financial and agricultural extension strategies most effectively	IFPRI					Kenya, India, Bangladesh	Causal impact assessment (quantitative)		Q4 2025	Q4 2027		

Gender Equality and Inclusion Accelerator MELIA Plan

enhance women's control over productive resources and improve their livelihood opportunities in agrifood systems?												
Social protection systems; research question: how effective are targeted social protection interventions in building the resilience in women and socially excluded groups within agrifood systems in climate affected and fragile settings?	IFPRI					Kenya, Ethiopia, Mali, Bangladesh, Egypt	Causal impact assessment (quantitative and qualitative)		Q4 2025	Q4 2027		
Interventions to amplify voice; research question: what is the impact of inclusive	IFPRI					WCA (Nigeria, Mali, Burkina Faso, Chad, Niger)	Causal impact assessment		Q1 2026	Q4 2028		

Gender Equality and Inclusion Accelerator MELIA Plan

leadership interventions on women's voice and agency in communities and on their livelihoods, food security and nutrition?												
Coordinated case studies on voice; research question: how do changes in women's voice and agency in communities influence food security, nutrition, poverty and biodiversity outcomes in AFS?	IFPRI, ABC, ICARDA						Causal impact assessment		Q1 2026	Q4 2027		
Youth integration; research question: what are the most effective approaches for integrating young men						TBD in ESA, WCA, SA	Causal impact assessment		2028	2029		

Gender Equality and Inclusion Accelerator MELIA Plan

and women into FLWS?												
Baseline study	Accelerator	Intermediate outcomes	TBD 3-4 outcomes				Survey and key informant interview		Q4 2025	Q1 2026		
Baseline study	Accelerator	Intermediate outcomes	TBD remaining outcomes not covered in the first baseline study				Survey and key informant interview		Q3 2026	Q4 2026		
Mid-term study	Accelerator	Intermediate outcomes	TBD				Survey and key informant interview; desk study/document review		Q2 2027	Q4 2027		
Endline study	Accelerator	Intermediate outcomes	TBD				Survey and key informant interview; desk study/document review		Q2 2030	Q4 2030		

MELIA study type is given for reference in **Annex 4**. An update version of this template will be shared once MELIA studies type will be defined.

Annex 3. MELIA budget templates

MELIA Budget: Staff Cost Breakdown by Year

Instructions: Replicate this reporting table for each year from 2025 to 2030 to plan staff and input costs accordingly. Additionally, you may add rows as necessary to cover each activity and staff type per activity.

This budget is only indicative and only relates to required personnel. Other costs will be determined on an annual basis, once all MELIA studies are confirmed.

Activity title	Activity description	Staff (# per type)	Full-time equivalent (# days)	Staff cost (USD)	Inputs <i>i.e. travel costs, special equipment costs</i>	Inputs cost (USD)	Total cost (USD)
Monitoring activities: Cross-cutting							
<i>Activities related to the routine monitoring of HLOs and outcomes</i>							
Annual data collection and reporting of HLO indicators		1 senior MEL expert	20% FTE	TBD		TBD	
		1 junior MEL expert	25% FTE	TBD			
MELIA studies: Cross-cutting							
<i>MELIA studies to evidence the achievement of program-level impacts and outcomes</i>							
Impact assessment studies		1 IA senior scientist	100% FTE	TBD		TBD	
		1 research assistant	30% FTE	TBD			
MELIA studies: AoW outcomes							
<i>MELIA studies to evidence the achievement of AoW-level intermediate outcomes not covered by any cross-cutting MELIA studies</i>							
Baseline study and biennial outcome studies		1 senior MEL expert	30% FTE	TBD		TBD	
		1 research assistant	30% FTE	TBD			
Total MELIA activity costs							

Next steps: Use the total cost column for each year to fill in the **MELIA Budget: Total Cost** table below.

MELIA Budget: Total Cost

Activity title	Activity description	2025–2030 Total cost (USD)					
		2025 (Budget)	2026 (Forecast)	2027 (Forecast)	2028 (Forecast)	2029 (Forecast)	2030 (Forecast)
1. Monitoring activities: Cross-cutting							
Activities related to the routine monitoring of HLOs and outcomes							
2. MELIA studies: Cross-cutting							
MELIA studies to evidence the achievement of program-level impacts and outcomes							
Sub-total: Cross-cutting MELIA costs							
3. MELIA studies: AoW outcomes							
MELIA studies to evidence the achievement of AoW-level intermediate outcomes not covered by any cross-cutting MELIA studies							
Sub-total: Other MELIA costs							
TOTAL: All MELIA costs							

Next steps: Activities and costs entered under sections 1 and 2 (captured by the cross-cutting sub-total) should be aggregated under the “cross-cutting” section of the **Plan of Results and Budget (PORB) template**, shared separately. Activities and costs entered under section 3 should be entered under the relevant AoW outcome in the PORB template.

Annex 4. MELIA study types

For reference only, the current MELIA study types defined in the [2024 Technical Reporting Guidance](#) are listed below. An updated MELIA studies typology will be shared in 2025.

Type	Definition
Causal Impact Assessment learning studies	These are research studies designed to test key assumptions underlying different steps of the causal chain (theory of change) that links CGIAR research/innovations to high-level impacts. As learning studies, they can be implemented in a 3-year cycle and use credible counterfactuals to provide early evidence of causal impacts of intermediary outcomes in the theory of change, and effectiveness of different approaches/interventions to improve such outcomes. This additional credible evidence becomes a relevant feedback to the research process that aims to maximize the impact of CGIAR related innovations in the long-term.
Adoption or diffusion studies addressing learning questions on the TOC	A study that identifies the spread, acquisition and use of social, institutional or technological innovations. Adoption and diffusion studies can address learning questions within an Initiative's theory/ies of change by documenting whether and how innovation/s have reached intended beneficiaries. Assessments of adoption/acquisition/use seek to identify whether innovation/s have been taken up or rejected by intended beneficiaries, in order to make a case for CGIAR contribution to outcome/s, relative to other potential influencing factors. Together, studies that encompass diffusion and adoption assessments show how innovations have spread to and been adopted or rejected by end users. Note: Adoption and diffusion studies do not necessarily assess impact. However, impact assessments may, and often do, include assessments of diffusion and adoption.
Tracing of scaling activities and policy advice, as a base for long-term, large scale impact assessments	LTLS impact studies usually require a longtime frame to observe high-level impacts associated to the use of CGIAR related innovations or policy recommendations. The design of these studies should be done from the start when CGIAR related innovations are ready to initiate the scaling process. The tracing activities should be designed in order to document how, when, where and why CGIAR related innovations and policy advice are disseminated or made to next users.
Qualitative outcome study	A study that assesses changes in behaviors, practices, perceptions or attitudes among beneficiaries of an innovation, or those who can facilitate the diffusion and adoption of an innovation (e.g., policymakers). Qualitative outcome studies are often used to substantiate contributions to policies, investments, budgets, curricula or similar.
Program/project evaluation or review	A program/project evaluation refers to a systematic and objective assessment of an on-going or completed program or project. Program evaluations focus on the evaluation of a set of time-bound interventions involving multiple activities that may cut across sectors, themes and/or geographic areas. These would also include evaluations of Initiatives. Project evaluations focus on the evaluation of an individual intervention designed to achieve specific objectives within specified resources and implementation schedules, often within the framework of a broader program. Evaluations are external, completely or largely independent, and systematic studies of an in-depth nature using clear evaluation criteria, whereas reviews may be more flexible and narrower in focus.
Ex-ante, baseline and/or foresight study	An ex-ante study, also known as a baseline study, is conducted before an intervention to determine the baseline conditions against which future change, outcomes and impact can be assessed. A foresight study involves the structured and explicit exploration of multiple futures in order to inform decision-making. Foresight studies are usually conducted at the beginning of an intervention, but may be used throughout the duration of a project or program to refine decision- and priority-making.
Scaling readiness assessment	An assessment of how “ready” innovations are for scaling and the appropriate actions for the acceleration and/or enhancement of scaling. Scaling readiness assessments can also identify which scaling bottlenecks need to be addressed, the most cost-effective scaling strategies, and which partners to engage.
Other MELIA activity (please specify)	A study or analysis related to monitoring, evaluation, learning or impact assessment that does not belong to the abovementioned types. The study or analysis will in some way test assumptions, inform learning and adaptive management, meet accountability requirements and/or inform the design of new Initiatives, programs and projects. When choosing “other MELIA activity”, you must justify how the study or analysis you are reporting constitutes a MELIA activity. Examples that could be added here include monitoring and synthesis studies.